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Tiny houses: movement or moment?

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ABSTRACT

Contemporary tiny houses are relatively recent phenomenon, claimed by some as a panacea for housing unaffordability and unsustainable development. It is difficult to assess these claims with any rigor because a definition of what constitutes a tiny house remains elusive. It is unclear whether they represent a small, specialized housing niche or a significant 'movement'. Drawing on data from questionnaire surveys and interviews conducted in Australia and social media, we argue the need to develop more precise definitions of the extent of tiny house living and the wider socio-cultural aspects underpinning claims of a new movement. We explore five major themes: four that motivate tiny house living—economic, secure tenure, sustainable community and freedom; and one deterrent—regulatory barriers. Our findings suggest the Australian tiny house movement is as much a manifestation of counter-cultural values as a preference for a specific dwelling type. This helps position tiny houses in the broader contemporary Australian housing market, enable preliminary international comparisons and allow some speculation about future trajectories.

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Tiny houses; subcultures; counter-culture; tiny house movement; housing affordability; tiny houses on wheels (THOW)

Introduction

This article examines the emergence of tiny houses as new feature of the housing market in Australia and explores whether there is also something that could be properly described as a 'tiny house movement', drawing some comparisons with the USA where it is perhaps most advanced. There is a paucity of academic literature on tiny houses—on their characteristics (size, design, cost, etc) as dwellings and on their constitution as part of a broader social movement—with much information coming from non-scholarly sources such as social and popular media (Evans, 2018b; Penfold *et al.*, 2018, Mangold & Zschau, 2019; Shearer & Burton, 2019). Even tiny houses understood simply as dwellings of a particular size is a poorly defined concept, although an attempt to rectify this was made by Shearer and Burton (2019), who categorized tiny houses by structural type—fixed or static, semi-mobile and fully mobile—and non-structural factors such as design, legal status, community and environmental focus.

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Much research on contemporary tiny houses focuses on tiny houses on wheels (THOW) and is preoccupied typically with dwelling types and how they are recognized in local government planning schemes (eg Evans, 2018b; Mingoya, 2015; Saxton, 2019). This article considers also those who live or aspire to live in tiny houses and like Colombini (2019), we focus on the counter-cultural or subcultural elements of tiny house living, where counter-cultural refers to ‘a set of values and norms significantly different from and often in direct contrast with the dominant norms and values that prevail today’ (Williams & Hannerz, 2014; Yinger, 1982, p. 15) and subcultural refers to the lifestyles of less explicitly oppositional but nevertheless unconventional social groups (Yinger, 1960). In doing so, it also reframes the discourse away from the complexities of defining the dwelling per se, and onto the characteristics of tiny house dwellers and supporters, what they advocate and whether this can be said to constitute a new social movement.

Contemporary manifestations of tiny houses, especially THOW, emerged in the USA in the late 1990s with early adopters including the designer Jay Schafer, the writer Lloyd Kahn and the architect Sarah Susanka (Bares *et al.*, 2017; Mitchell, 2014). Their popularity grew considerably after the Global Financial Crisis of 2008, and has been subsequently driven (in part) by the production of desire ‘for experiences rather than things’ promoted by new and emerging social media (Bauman, 2004; Colombini, 2019; Penfold *et al.*, 2018). In Australia, THOW increased in popularity from the beginning of the 21st century, although only around 200–300 people are believed to currently live in such dwellings, unlike the USA where it is estimated some 10,000 people live in tiny houses (Wenban, 2018). Their popularity has been attributed to economic factors such as housing affordability, a desire among some to live a more environmentally sustainable lifestyle and the ability to enjoy greater ‘freedom’ from certain social and economic obligations associated with more conventional lifestyles (Anson, 2014; Evans, 2018b, 2019; Mutter, 2013). ‘Freedom’ is a persistent narrative in debates and discussions about tiny house living, especially among protagonists and as a response to the increasing financialization of housing that is an important feature of contemporary neoliberal capitalism (Colombini, 2019; Rogers & Power, 2017). Tiny house living is also seen as a way to free up time from wage labor and access resources to experience other aspects of life including travel and spending more time (and money) on hobbies and other leisure pursuits (Bartlett, 2016; Bauman, 2004; Mangold & Zschau, 2019; Penfold *et al.*, 2018; Smith, 2006).

This article reports on a multistage cross-sectional research project exploring the attitudes of people in Australia interested in tiny houses. The study commenced in 2015 and is ongoing. To date, three self-completion questionnaire surveys and a series of interviews have been conducted with tiny house dwellers and builders and other interested parties (see Table 1). The article first describes the emergence of contemporary tiny houses: how they evolved in the historical trajectory of the Australian and USA housing markets; and the extent of tiny house living in both countries. Second, it focuses on the Australian context and discusses the factors driving the demand for tiny houses and the barriers experienced by those trying to develop and/or live in them. Third, it describes the methods used to collect and analyze data and then presents the results through the exploration of five major themes that emerged from

Table 1. Summary of research methods.

Method	Date	valid n	Notes
Questionnaire Survey 1	June 2015	56	80% aged 40+; 57% female; 10/56 tiny house dweller
Questionnaire Survey 2	Sept 2017	369	78% aged 40+; 67% female; 52/369 tiny house dweller
Questionnaire Survey 3 (ATHA)	Sept 2019	640	66% aged 40+; 78% female; 170/640 tiny house dweller
Interviews	Jan 2015–present	12	Mix of genders and ages; younger couples more common, 3 had young children
Participant Observation	Jan 2015–present	N/A	Attended and spoke at numerous tiny house gatherings, festivals and Meetups

the data: reduction of debt, security of tenure, ‘environmental sustainability’, a search for freedom and the impact of regulatory barriers. The article concludes by discussing whether tiny houses should be conceived not just by dwelling type or size, but also by the cultural assumptions and expectations of those choosing this dwelling type and lifestyle. We conclude that tiny houses are not, as some claim, a panacea for solving the problems of housing affordability, but may be able to provide desirable and potentially more affordable dwellings for certain demographic groups at particular points in their life course. We also argue that the attractions of some aspects of tiny house living have the potential to drive positive changes in the way developers and house builders consider more diverse housing products.

Conceptualizing the tiny house counterculture

At the outset it is important to acknowledge that the notion of tiny houses discussed here is primarily a phenomenon limited to a few English-speaking developed countries, such as the USA, New Zealand and Australia, and some European countries including France, Germany and the Netherlands. In many other parts of the world most people live in small dwellings, often self-built out of necessity and with very limited formal access to public services or amenities such as power, water and sewerage. This is not a lifestyle choice or part of a desire to live out some notion of simplified living, driven mainly by the production of desire for <consuming> experiences rather than things (often resulting from social media trends), but a brute necessity driven by poverty and lack of opportunity (Penfold *et al.*, 2018; Smith, 2006).

Most Australian cities are characterized by swathes of relatively large, detached single-family homes in suburban settings—in the latest Census, conducted in 2016–66% of capital city and 73% of all dwellings in Australia were detached houses (ABS, 2016; idCommunity, 2020). Australia also has some of the largest average house sizes in the world, although this has not always been the norm. Prior to the 1950s, Australian houses were relatively small (around 90 m² for an average household of 3.6 people) and most city dwellers lived in terraced housing, semi-detached homes or flats and apartments (Davison, 1993, 2006). Shortly after the end of the WW2, the Victorian Government even imposed a 116 m² upper limit on house size (McKinlay *et al.*, 2016).

From the 1970s however, new houses grew in size, partly due to the inclusion of garages within their footprint (McKinlay *et al.*, 2016), but also because the economic boom of the mid-1980s increased access to housing credit, with households on modest incomes able to afford larger dwellings. In recent years, the average size of all new

dwelling in Australia has dropped slightly, due mostly to the burgeoning number of new apartments, although the median size of newly constructed detached houses is still around 230 m², amongst the biggest in the world (Commsec, 2018).

Alongside the increase in median house size has been a small yet significant movement towards smaller dwellings. A celebration of smaller housing is of course not new; for example, as far back as the 1850s, Henry David Thoreau in his influential book *Walden; or, Life in the Woods*, demonstrated the virtues of a simple, downsized life by building his own (tiny) house to promote self-sufficiency and avoid debt (Anson, 2014; Diguette, 2017; Ford & Gomez-Lanier, 2017). In the late 1940s, significant numbers of prefabricated and relatively small houses were built in response to housing shortages after the end of WW2 (Hayden, 2004) while from the 1960s, the emergence of the environmental counterculture saw a resurgence in the popularity of smaller, more sustainable houses—although more evident in the USA than in Australia (Bares *et al.*, 2017; Evans, 2018b). Nonetheless, the mainstream of housing development in both countries still involved the construction of relatively large detached houses in expanding suburban localities. By the late 1990s however, the economic climate was less conducive to this growth trend in Australia—a lack of well-paid and secure employment opportunities together with rising house prices saw a growing problem of housing unaffordability, not just in terms of direct housing costs but also in the cost of commuting from residential dormitory suburbs to major employment centers (Dodson & Sipe, 2008). While house prices dropped temporarily during the Global Financial Crisis, this was short lived, and prices began rising again, making owner occupation and indeed renting increasingly unaffordable for growing numbers and subjecting more households to housing stress (see AHURI (2019) and Davison *et al.* (2012)).

Adding to the cost of housing in the USA is the International Residential Code which mandates at least one room no smaller than 120 square feet (11.15 m²), with other rooms of at least 70 square feet (6.5 m²) (Kilman, 2016; Nonko, 2016; Wenban, 2018), restricting those with limited budgets from building smaller and more affordable houses (Wilson & Boehland, 2008). In Australia, the Building Code of Australia (BCA) (within the National Construction Code series) does not mandate minimum room sizes, but THOW struggle to comply with these Code requirements because of the low ceiling heights of loft bedrooms, energy efficiency requirements and steep access stairs (Liu *et al.*, 2019; Strachan, 2018). Arguably a greater deterrent to building smaller in Australia lies with the lending requirements of banks, which will typically not lend (in the form of mortgages) on dwellings smaller than 40 m² or on mobile dwellings (Robb, 2016).

Since the turn of the century, increasing numbers of people began questioning the conspicuous consumption and excessive resource use epitomized by overly large suburban houses and by the economic and social costs of commuting (Ford & Gomez-Lanier, 2017; Saxton, 2019). More recently, social movements based on principles such as voluntary simplicity, minimalism, decluttering and slow living have grown in popularity (Colombini, 2019; Penfold *et al.*, 2018). Focused nominally on reducing environmental impacts and the household carbon footprint, members of these movements are concerned also with rising levels of household debt and achieving a better work-life balance (Mangold & Zschau, 2019). A quest for experiences rather than

‘things’, driven in part by the influence of social media such as Instagram, is also evident (Mangold & Zschau, 2019; Penfold *et al.*, 2018) and resonates with the tiny house promise of enabling greater freedom from regular employment and freedom to travel for longer periods of time. Penfold *et al.* (2018, p. 169) highlight the inherent contradictions in claiming tiny houses as models of sustainability: ‘Rather than rejecting what some tiny house media represent as the ‘fast’ capitalist world, the tiny house is represented as a pathway towards increasing non-household related consumption activities, such as travel, leisure, social life and so forth’.

What are tiny houses?

Tiny houses as dwellings are not homogenous and are not easy to classify. Shearer and Burton (2019) categorized them according to three structural factors (mobility, size and design) and four societal factors (affordability, sustainability, legal status and community focus). Definitions of tiny houses vary widely; for example, a residential structure under 400 square feet (37.5 m²), fully mobile on a trailer base (THOW), partly mobile (on a non-permanent foundation) or fixed (as in an Accessory Dwelling Unit (ADU)), see Australian Tiny House Association (ATHA, 2020). This variability makes it difficult for most local governments to devise appropriate and sensitive regulatory frameworks and policies, particularly as THOW are considered as temporary dwellings or caravans, with most local governments then imposing restrictions on the duration of occupancy.

Critically, the promoters of THOW (mostly in the USA) have deliberately sought to classify them as Recreational Vehicles (RVs), to differentiate them from mobile homes (also known as manufactured or trailer homes), not least to avoid the perceived stigma often associated with this housing type (Anson, 2014; Baird, 2017; Evans, 2018a). Manufactured homes in the USA were originally sold as affordable housing to low income groups but now, proximity to trailer parks is considered by some as detrimental to neighboring property values (Baird, 2017; Evans, 2017).

In Australia, THOW are regulated as caravans, but are generally designed and constructed to similar standards as conventional houses built on permanent foundations. If the definition of a THOW is, however, merely one of mobility and legal status, then to all intents and purposes, it is a caravan. However, if it embodies some of the characteristics referred to in Shearer and Burton (2019) such as a community and sustainability focus and DIY/design, then it is different to a typical caravan. Perhaps the difference is more one of culture than structure as, arguably, THOW dwellers typically see themselves as part of a separate sub-culture to caravanners who do not live permanently in their caravans or are ‘grey nomads’ who continually travel (Onyx & Leonard 2005).

What drives the take-up of tiny houses?

Arguably, some of the strongest motivators behind the interest in tiny houses are economic factors (Kilman 2016). THOW offer people a chance to own a home of their own, while avoiding many of the direct costs associated with owning land (Kilman, 2016). Another strong motivator is environmental sustainability and it is often claimed that tiny houses exemplify a conscious environmental ethos, by promoting more sustainable off-grid living (Anson, 2014; Evans 2018a; Mutter, 2013; Penfold

et al., 2018). Finally, freedom from mortgage debt and the associated obligations of permanent and full-time paid employment are characteristic of a countercultural movement that rejects the conventions of mainstream society (Anson, 2014; Boeckermann *et al.*, 2019; Evans, 2019; Mutter, 2013).

Economic factors. The ‘biggest incentive for living tiny is saving money’ (Kilman, 2016, p. 2) whilst still owning a house, albeit a tiny one. Tiny houses can provide some with an ‘affordable’ home without too much debt and one they might also be able to build themselves. The traditional (permanent, built) housing market in Australia has become increasingly unaffordable to a growing proportion of the population (Cox & Pavletich, 2018). Conversely, the price of detached houses in Australia has risen during the COVID-19 pandemic (2020), and this is likely to exacerbate affordability issues, especially combined with high unemployment rates and associated poverty among a significant proportion of the population (Wiesel *et al.*, 2020). Housing stress is even more evident among renters, with low income renters often spending 60% or more of total income on housing (Anglicare, 2019) and a rise in house prices and drop in rental availability during the COVID pandemic has exacerbated the problem (Pawson *et al.*, 2021). The rental market in Australia is characterized by insecurity with long leases a rarity and many restrictions on use of the property.

Home ownership has been steadily decreasing as a share of all tenures in Australia, particularly for younger people, with significantly greater numbers renting rather than buying (ABS, 2017; Anglicare, 2019; Anglicare Australia, 2017). Many older people too are now reaching retirement age with outstanding mortgage debts or no housing assets following a lifetime of renting (Collett, 2018; Goodman *et al.*, 2013). Women are especially vulnerable to housing stress, as many have very modest retirement income from superannuation or pensions and may have lost a house due to relationship breakdown (Petersen & Parsell, 2015; Yates *et al.*, 2007). Perhaps as a consequence, young people and women over the age of 55 are over-represented among those interested in the opportunities offered by tiny house living (Mangold & Zschau, 2019; Shearer & Burton, 2019). Nevertheless, tiny house advocates rarely if ever question the dominant narrative of home ownership so prevalent in Australia and elsewhere, sharing the view apparently that renting is a tenure of last resort and not something freely chosen (Nelson & Schneider, 2018).

But are tiny houses necessarily more affordable than more conventional dwellings? Most THOW are more expensive to build per square meter than most conventional newly built homes and appear cheaper overall only because they do not necessarily require the purchase of land and associated infrastructure. In Australia, a growing number of builders sell bespoke THOW, priced from around \$40,000 to \$120,000. A THOW is usually 15–30 m²—for example, a typical example is the tiny house built by the major Queensland tiny house builder is 7.2 m long and 2.4 m wide (the total floor area including loft is 24.43 m²) and costs \$89,000 or \$3,640 per square meter (Aussie Tiny Houses, 2020). In contrast, a basic three-bedroom detached house in a master planned community can cost just over \$1,000 per square meter (Delahunty, 2019; Coral Homes, 2020). Nevertheless, a tiny house can be built for less than a conventional house, even if land costs are excluded, if owners are able to contribute their labor and

use some recycled materials (Kilman, 2016). Moreover, unlike the rather inflexible products of volume builders, THOW builders typically offer greater flexibility and a wider range of options, including selling basic shell designs that can then be customized.

In the USA, the tiny house market is more advanced, and it is estimated there are around 85-90 tiny house builders, although this is complicated by the overlap between the established RV/manufactured homes markets and THOW sector (Baird, 2017; Evans, 2019; Sisson, 2017). They can also be relatively expensive (costing upwards of US\$50,000) but tend to be larger and more luxurious with greater choice than in Australia (Kilman, 2016) and finance, in the form of personal loans or specific RV finance, is more readily available. In Australia, it can be very difficult to obtain finance to purchase or build a THOW, even using a personal loan and so building relies typically on cash savings or having sufficient employment income. This is a major barrier to the wider take-up of THOW as loans are unsecured and the structure is treated, like a car or a caravan, as a depreciating asset. It is not relevant to fixed tiny houses, but those require land ownership, which is out of reach for many.

Environmental sustainability. It is frequently claimed that tiny houses are more environmentally sustainable than conventional houses (Carlin, 2014; Jones & Kammen, 2011; Saxton, 2019; Shearer & Burton, 2019; Wilson & Boehland, 2008). Tiny houses, simply because of their scale, use proportionately fewer resources, especially when constructed from recycled materials. Moreover, because many tiny houses and particularly THOW are capable of running off-grid, generating their own power, collecting their own rainwater and using composting toilets (Kilman, 2016), their occupants are obliged to confront their use and possible waste of resources (Anson, 2014; Kilman, 2016; Saxton, 2019). Living off-grid forces people to ensure the water tank is full, batteries are charged, and the composting toilet is working efficiently, which may increase awareness of resource use and reduce wasteful consumption (Saxton, 2019). Tiny house living might also foster more sustainable behavior—after moving to a tiny house, Saxton (2019) found ecological footprints were reduced by around 45%. Other environmentally sustainable behaviors included using more public or active transport, using renewable energy, harvesting rainwater, and minimizing overall consumption (Saxton, 2019). Conversely, tiny house dwellers in rural areas increased their car usage; and like residents of urban micro apartments, urban tiny house dwellers reported eating out more often (Anson, 2014; Clinton, 2018).

Freedom. A persistent theme among tiny house advocates is that of ‘freedom’ (Anson, 2014; Bennett, 2019; Boeckermann *et al.*, 2019) although even in this context, it is a somewhat nebulous and ill-defined term. It can refer to economic factors and to notions of tiny houses as part of a more affordable lifestyle. In this respect tiny houses are assumed to provide opportunities for increased freedom from the full-time wage labor needed to save for housing deposits, make mortgage payments and acquire the trappings of a settled ‘good life’ or to free up money for travel and entertainment (Mangold & Zschau, 2019).

Other interpretations of freedom are more nuanced and complex, ranging from freedom to move at will, through freedom from regulations to an almost Thoreauvian

version of voluntary simplicity in contrast to the complexities of modern life (Alexander *et al.*, 2018; Mangold & Zschau, 2019). Despite the widespread use of the term by tiny house advocates, there appears minimal reflection on its meaning. Tiny house dwellers are constantly beset by complicated decisions, such as where to park legally, what to do with waste from composting toilets, how to deal with lack of privacy and how to become part of a community (Mutter, 2013; Vail, 2016). Moreover, moving from consuming manufactured products to consuming experiences is not economic freedom, as Bauman (2004, p. 32) states ‘... it is the aesthetics of consumption that now rules where the work ethic once ruled. For the successful alumni of consumer training the world is an immense matrix of possibilities, of intense and ever more intense sensations, of deep and deeper still experiences’.

Barriers to tiny house living

In response to the restrictions imposed by most Australian local governments, some who see themselves as part of a countercultural movement deliberately advocate for THOW to be classified as caravans and not as permanent dwellings. For example, after a legal challenge, Brisbane City Council ruled that a young couple’s THOW was neither a building nor a structure and was instead a road-registered moveable dwelling (BDDRC, 2016, p. 2). This is likely a Pyrrhic victory as they are now subject to limits on the length of occupation and avoiding compliance with minimum building standards may lead to poorly constructed and even unsafe structures.

Currently however, moveable dwellings cannot comply with the requirements of the BCA (Alexander *et al.*, 2018; Strachan 2018) and need comply only with road use regulations which restrict length, width, height and weight. Most local governments in Australia consider THOW as caravans which are permitted in planning schemes primarily at designated caravan sites. If used as dwellings, caravans are regulated under byelaws with restricted periods of habitation and a range of conditions, differing between and within local governments.

Some in the tiny house movement, mostly urban planners and tiny house builders, have hypothesized ways that THOW can get around limited permissible periods of habitation, and reside for longer periods. The Tiny House Resource Guide (Bares *et al.*, 2017) identified several potential Australian options, including letting backyards to THOW, the creation of tiny house villages or small lot housing. Most already exist, for example as caravan parks or medium density residential zones. The problem is, most caravans and probably THOW do not comply with minimum standards to be permitted as a permanent dwelling. Anecdotally, there is strong opposition by a large sector of the tiny house movement to legalizing THOW in this manner (Tiny Houses Australia, 2017).

While THOW are generally more accepted in the USA than Australia, this is not universal. Homeowner and homeowner association attitudes often depend on how tiny houses are integrated into existing urban areas with some preferring specific zones rather than allowing ad hoc parking (Evans, 2018b). These attitudes are, of course, not new as Jackson (1985) described in *Crabgrass Frontier* and Fogelson (2007) documented in *Bourgeois Nightmares*. Attitudes reflect broader sociocultural factors—towns with strong countercultural lifestyles were more positive towards tiny houses than more conservative places as Evans (2018b) found. Nonetheless most

homeowners still had reservations that tiny houses as urban infill (even if permanent ADUs) might decrease property values; and all strongly opposed the use of tiny houses for short term tourism lets such as Airbnb (Evans, 2018b).

The majority of these barriers apply to THOW rather than fixed tiny houses, which are legal in all local governments in Australia and most of the USA—so long as the tiny house is approved as a dwelling. In many Australian local government areas, even a temporary dwelling such as a shed, shipping container or THOW is permitted as long as the landowner has plans to build an approved house. Unlike the USA, there are rarely minimum sizes for houses, but the BCA mandates minimum room sizes and ceiling heights (Wenban, 2018). Generally speaking, landowners are not particularly interested in tiny houses, as they find it relatively easy to get mortgage finance for a more standard dwelling with the most common tiny house in such cases usually the ADU.

Given these restrictions on occupancy, the need to comply with road use legislation, the lack of finance and the potential for hostility from neighbors, it is not surprising that so few people in Australia choose to live in THOW. However, it is important to explore in more detail the views and experiences of those who do make this choice, both for its own sake and to better understand whether people might be willing to choose this path under more favorable circumstances and whether this, in turn, has the potential for tiny houses of all types to make a more significant contribution to the Australian housing landscape.

Method

To understand why people chose to live in a tiny house and what barriers they faced, the study used an exploratory, multi-method approach including three questionnaire surveys with closed and open questions (Table 1) and scrutiny of tiny house social media sites (Langston, 2020; Tiny Houses Australia, 2020; Tiny Houses Brisbane, 2020). Short semi-structured interviews were conducted with 12 tiny house dwellers and three builders. Finally, the primary author attended tiny house gatherings and stayed overnight in two tiny houses (see Figure 1 for a typical tiny house on display).

Survey respondents were gathered by convenience and snowball sampling of known populations, posted to Facebook groups and known contacts of the researchers, with a request to forward the email. Survey 3 was conducted by ATHA collaboratively with Author 1. Interviewees were recruited in a similar manner to the survey participants and conducted face-to-face or by Skype. Each participant gave written consent to being interviewed and recorded and qualitative comments and author notes were analyzed in NVivoTM. Data was classified according to whether the respondent lived or had lived in a tiny house and by gender and age. Tiny house builders were considered separately to provide information on who was buying tiny houses, and cost and construction. The sample was not randomly selected, and we cannot, therefore, infer the views and preferences of the population at large. Note also, that most results reporting are from Surveys 2 and 3, as Survey 1 had only 56 valid responses.

The text inputs were initially coded for common themes, which were further refined using axial coding. This resulted in five major themes (economic factors, security of tenure, sustainable community, freedom, and planning restrictions), which



Figure 1. THOW display model at Tiny House Festival (image courtesy of Author 1).

overlapped to some extent but were distinct enough to form their own categories. Two themes were broadly related to economic factors (economic factors and security of tenure) and freedom and local government planning were deemed discrete concepts. Environmental sustainability was interrelated with the search for community, so was termed sustainable community.

The Findings section (below) is augmented by using selected quotes from interviewees and survey participants. While all voices and comments are important, further details are given on selected interviewees (given pseudonyms for privacy, with survey participants identified by age and gender) to illuminate the themes in more detail and highlight the lived experience in tiny houses.

Findings

First, this section describes the demographics of the samples, and then it discusses the key themes, which have been differentiated into four motivations (economic factors, security of tenure, sustainable community, and freedom) and one challenge (local government planning).

Demographics of tiny house advocates

Eighteen percent of respondents (10/56) of Survey 1; 14% of respondents (52/369) of Survey 2, 27% (170/640) of Survey 3 and all 12 interviewees had built or were building a tiny house (see [Table 1](#)). Another 68% (249) of Survey 2 respondents intended

to build a tiny house. Approximately half had built or intended to build the tiny house themselves and the rest intended to purchase one from a bespoke tiny house builder. The majority preferred a THOW rather than a fixed or semi mobile tiny dwelling (67% in Survey 2 and 78% in Survey 3). One third of actual dwellers had funded the tiny house with cash, another third from ongoing employment income and the final third funded their tiny houses from a combination of sources, including bartering labor for materials.

In all surveys, most respondents were female (67%) and over 40 years of age (68%) with 33% over 50. In contrast, seven of the interviewees were aged under 40, with the remaining three aged over 50. Contrary to assumptions that tiny houses are only suitable for singles or childless couples, a small proportion of tiny house dwellers had children. Out of 170 tiny house dwellers in Survey 3, 13 tiny house dwellers had one child and 11 had two. Interviewee Lauren lived in a self-built tiny house with her partner and three children aged 8, 11 and 12. She rented part of a large property in a rural residential area of South East Queensland, and her site also included a large tent and a shipping container for storage. She said:

I actually enjoy to live in a smaller space, because you don't feel overwhelmed, and with kids you can see all the time, you can hear them and see what they're up to (Lauren, 30s).

By the time of writing (late-2020), Lauren was trying to sell her tiny house, and many others had moved to more conventional dwellings generally due to a lack of space in the tiny house (mostly young couples who had started or grown their family). Interviewees Simon and Megan built a tiny house themselves in rural Tasmania out of two 20-foot shipping containers. They found it too difficult to raise their active toddler in the small space, especially in winter, and had relocated to rural Queensland. Megan spoke of driving an hour daily to take her son to playgroup or for social activities with other new mothers. She spoke eloquently of the problems, but also the benefits of living in a tiny house:

Living in a tiny house with kids stretches you and teaches you lessons you'd never known without the experience. It teaches you to be creative with space and play. Our bed doubled as the lounge, change table and play area. It had its challenges for sure but it definitely drew our family together (Megan, 20s)

Regarding the location of their tiny house, 38% of Survey 2 respondents and 5 interviewees lived in rural areas to escape city stress—and because land was cheaper. Jill, who was single and had been living in inner city Sydney, felt she was '*... a bit jaded with the hamster treadmill*' and wanted more time to travel. After visiting a friend who lived in a tiny house, she built her own in a rural area in Victoria. In contrast, many wished to live in or near capital cities (35% of Survey 2 respondents and 5 interviewees), to access employment, transport and health care.

Needs to be close to public transport and local services including clinics. Nothing outside of major cities where [the] jobs and services are available (Male, 30s)

Despite their passion for tiny houses, most seemed firmly wedded to the '*... aspirational narrative of owning one's own home*' (Nelson & Schneider, 2018) and viewed them as a step on the ladder to the '*great Australian dream*' of more

conventional property ownership. Almost all expressed a desire to own their own land, after saving money by living on someone else's property. They then wanted to use the tiny house as a base whilst building another (presumably larger) house. Most were pragmatic about the location and understood it would more likely be in a rural area due to land cost and more stringent planning restrictions on urban blocks. Louis, a young man in his 20s, lived with his partner in a self-built tiny house in the backyard of his parent's property in Brisbane, Queensland. Their dream was to eventually buy their own land but were limited by the need to live closer to the city for work purposes.

Economic factors

Economic factors were the dominant reasons given for considering tiny house living and included the cost of buying or renting conventional housing, preference for detached dwellings, freedom from debt, the ability to leave or retire from work, moving out of the parental home or share houses, and avoiding homelessness. Many used discretionary savings or employment income to build their tiny house and reported that it was almost impossible to obtain bank finance for a tiny house, even if on foundations. As a survey respondent commented, '*...banks in Australia typically do not lend on buildings which are less than 50sqm in area*' (Male, 50s).

People often become interested in tiny houses after a personal crisis such as divorce, the birth of a child, losing a job, death of a partner or illness (Mangold & Zschau, 2019). Economic factors were common, including the inability to find work, or to pay a mortgage; highlighting that the role of tiny houses may be a counterbalance to the lack of social welfare support and not necessarily a countercultural response. Nonetheless, while some of the interviewees could be considered in the low to medium income quartiles, none were in a position that tiny houses were their only housing choice. Indeed, tiny houses are relatively expensive, and for these people, their motivation was both countercultural (wanting to downsize) and seeking 'freedom' (a 'detached house of their own rather than an attached rental dwelling'). For example, Mandy, in her 30s, lives in a tiny house with her husband and two children, on a rural property which also has a standard house, cottage and another tiny house. She spoke of re-evaluating their finances after having children:

<We were> kind of a bit loose with our money <but> post kids, we got a shock and had to go on one income. We didn't have any money saved and were looking at a minimum five to six hundred thousand house. So, we started asking ourselves did we really want what everyone else had, the big huge house and the fancy cars? (Mandy, 30s)

Affordability was more nuanced than just not being able to afford a mortgage. Some were in genuine housing distress, particularly older and more vulnerable people, but others preferred a detached house to an apartment, and to own rather than rent.

I'm a single woman and I don't need a big house with multiple empty bedrooms, but I'd also like to live somewhere I can have a pet and a veggie garden. A tiny house on its own patch of land would be an excellent compromise. (Female, 50s)

For some, as Mangold and Zschau (2019) found, there was a strong emphasis on freeing up time for what they saw as more meaningful life experiences, including

travel. It was quite nuanced however, as some wanted it for both affordability and to have more experiences:

We could place one on our farm to assist my 50-year-old sister who is on the verge of homelessness (can't afford rent as she is single). I would also consider this as a retirement option between 60 and 70 as I want to travel and not have my money tied up in real estate. (Female, 50s)

Many spoke of wanting quality and not quantity and to afford 'better' fixtures and fittings. This emphasis on quality, authenticity and good design to some extent represents the antithesis of 'bigger is better' mass consumerism, including the desire to live in McMansions (Ford & Gomez-Lanier, 2017), but of course, is also consumerism, albeit in a different form.

I can have everything I want in a tiny house that I design myself- I don't have to compromise, and I can afford it, I couldn't afford it with a regular mortgage.

(Female, 40s)

Security of tenure

One notable theme was the appeal of tiny houses for more vulnerable people, particularly older, single women, who were concerned about becoming homeless, mostly due to the insecurity of the private rental system. They felt their pension was inadequate and that tiny houses could allow them both financial independence and a greater degree of security of tenure.

<I'm a> single woman over 65 on a pension. I'm terribly concerned as to what will happen to me when the owners of my currently rented property decide to sell. I can't afford to live anywhere else and I'm sick and tired of moving. I would like some security in my life for a change and a tiny house is the ONLY way I'm going to get that (Female, 60s)

Health issues were also a major concern to some and as Janet, a single woman in her 50s expressed, building her tiny house not only saved her from homelessness, but supported her mental health.

I was homeless following an acute mental health incident. After sleeping in my car for some time a friend offered me a free room in kind for garden work. I ... started to collect timber, roofing products & other building offcuts from the local tip/rubbish & recycling center. This 'project' is supporting my recovery. (Janet, 50s)

Other vulnerable groups saw tiny houses as a potential 'solution' for some other societal issues, including places of refuge for people escaping domestic violence.

Easy construction - assist families in crisis. Many women with children flee domestic violence. Refuges are closing from lack of funding. It offers somewhere safe (a backyard) and protected. (Female, 40s)

Importantly however, the design of most THOW is unsuited to most with mobility problems, a majority having loft bedrooms only accessible by stairs or ladders. It is also important to reiterate the importance of tenure, building quality, health and safety; some marginal renters in caravan parks for example, have been housed in caravans that failed to comply with minimum health and safety standards, with limited options to move should the caravan park be sold (Goodman *et al.*, 2013).

Sustainable community

In Survey 2, most respondents (295 out of 369) emphasized environmental sustainability. Tiny house advocates frequently refer to the excesses of consumerism and wanting to give back to (or perhaps take less from) the environment. Tiny house living is seen by some as a pushback against the greed and excess of recent decades and the isolation of big houses in the suburbs (Lee & Ahn, 2016). Interrelated with environmental sustainability was the desire to live in a community of other tiny house dwellers. Mandy, who we cited earlier, said:

We started looking at what was important to us. We want to explore the arts, eating organically and getting back in connection with nature and the environment, and social and communities (Mandy, 30s)

Other contemporary concerns, such as an interest in minimalism and downsizing were evident:

I support tiny houses for conscious consuming. We all consume too much land, infrastructure and space for what we need. We choose to fill up the spaces with more stuff and also travel further to our destinations using more fuel to get there. (Female, 40s).

Most tiny house dwellers chose to live 'off grid', disconnected from the main urban utilities, but this aspect also generated the most complaints about tiny house living, especially the management of sewage. Simon and Megan in Tasmania had a composting toilet which required separation of solid and liquid waste. She said it was clean and didn't smell, but her toddler had played with the liquid waste container. Mandy said her composting toilet helped her children learn not to waste resources:

'... it smells better than a normal loo ... the kids are not used to flushing, so when we go to the <normal> toilet, I say, you've got to flush, and the kids say, why, I just did a wee'

Despite the expressed desire to live in community, most tiny house dwellers lived as any other residents of detached houses, with minimal sharing of facilities and resources with their neighbors, although many urban dwellers were enthusiastic users of public resources such as parks and libraries (largely through necessity rather than philosophy). Much of the motivation for sustainable community seems inextricably related to the desire for 'freedom', specifically for a detached house with a backyard; for example, many were unwilling to live in intentional communities (ICs), apartments or caravan parks, most commonly because of restrictions on pets (frequently banned from ICs because they predate on wildlife).

My vision is to include pets/animal sanctuary with an organic community garden which would provide for me and other like-minded seniors. I cannot imagine a life without animals and think a communal approach with off-leash areas would be perfect in so many ways. (Female, 50s)

Freedom

The search for 'freedom' was a complicated and composite theme. On the surface this referred to economic freedom, but it also reflected a desire for freedom from day to day responsibility and to travel, as well as freedom from regulation in where one is permitted to live or even how one's house is built. Freedom is the most obvious way in which tiny house advocates may be viewed as a minority, counter-cultural

phenomenon, popular mainly with old or new ‘hippies’, with only limited appeal to the majority (Anson, 2014), as well as an equally small, but more contemporary group of ‘hipsters’ with a penchant for authenticity and superdiversity (Maly & Varis, 2016; Vertovec, 2007). The DIY aspect of freedom (like the ‘right to repair movement’) is a strong ideal in the tiny house counterculture, in that the first tiny houses were typically designed and built by architects and owner builders.

Others, mostly younger males less concerned about security of tenure, felt regulation would impose too many restrictions on tiny houses. Local governments were viewed as unnecessarily risk averse, imposing onerous laws and too responsive to NIMBY political pressures. For some, if the council would not approve their tiny house, they intended to live illegally, ‘... *under the radar*,’ and move it if necessary. They were also willing to fight the system:

Nearly finished mine, its sick, it’s at the beach. We love it. Can’t wait to smash beers on holidays in my tiny house. Fought the council over it and won (Male, 20s)

Many who were anti regulation wanted to live in rural areas, ‘... *where planning rules are less restrictive*’ and ‘*I’ve heard of people who hide away in forests to avoid councils finding them*’. In rural and remote areas of Australia, particularly Tasmania, temporary dwelling in unapproved dwellings known as holiday ‘shacks’ is not uncommon (Dufty-Jones, 2018; Selwood & Jones, 2010). Local governments sometimes overlook or are unaware of these, but neighbor complaints may precipitate a notice to leave. Some rural areas have a relatively large number of unapproved dwellings, whether shacks, tiny houses or other informal dwellings such as sheds or container houses. These areas often have an informal neighborhood watch, warning of visits by council inspectors, which creates a somewhat insular community. Megan and Simon’s container house was unapproved and they were reluctant to let strangers on to the land; even emergency services. This however, fostered a strong sense of community, and resident networks (sometimes using personal drones) also warned of bushfires and stock thieves.

Local government planning

Local government planning and building restrictions were viewed as the biggest obstacle faced by most actual or prospective tiny house dwellers. In Australia, the regulation of land uses and development under local planning schemes and byelaws is complex and differs between states and between local governments, with most not recognizing THOW as a separate dwelling type (Bares *et al.*, 2017; Shearer *et al.*, 2018). This complex and uncertain regulatory environment can be very stressful especially if a person has invested most of their financial assets in the property. Mary, an elderly single lady living in a suburban area had chosen to move from a rented shared apartment and spent her superannuation (pension) on building a tiny house. Mary loved the independence of living alone in her own home, and her THOW had been designed especially for her needs (no steps or loft bedroom), was quite luxurious (for a THOW) and was close to all services. Nonetheless, the confusing and inconsistent regulatory regime around tiny houses, especially in her suburban location, was a source of some distress to her:

‘... you don’t know who might complain ... and I might have to move out. If it doesn’t work out, then what? I’ve got nowhere to go; I’ve put all my money in.’ (Mary, 70s).

Some local governments were viewed as more progressive, but the planning landscape overall was fluid and advice to THOW dwellers often differed between individual planners. Many local governments are also reluctant to de-regulate or legitimize tiny house living due to the possibility of complaints from existing homeowners, supporting the findings of Evans (2018b).

Apart from a strong minority who felt that tiny houses should never be subject to regulation, a large proportion (albeit mostly builders and those wishing to live in a tiny house) thought local governments should permit THOW as permanent dwellings, with appropriate controls over environmental and waste management and construction standards. They felt this would give certainty of tenure, as well as allow for the expansion of the tiny house building market.

Conclusions

Much scholarly work on tiny houses has focused on them as a dwelling type rather than as an important element of an emerging social movement. There has also been an emphasis on tiny houses as a possible response (albeit not a solution) to the growing problem of housing affordability and as a contributor to a more sustainable housing stock. This article has focused instead on tiny houses as part of an emerging broader social movement with distinct subcultural and even countercultural elements, characterized more by the socio-cultural ambitions of its proponents than by dwelling size or design per se. Defining tiny houses purely by size, design or mobility is problematic, not least because it is then difficult to argue that caravans or studio units, for example, are *not* tiny houses. On the other hand, concentrating on the socio-cultural aspirations of members of the tiny house movement might serve to position it as principally a countercultural movement whose members all subscribe to a coherent critique of the neoliberal financialization and commodification of housing. While some tiny house advocates certainly espouse these views, not all do and could be described as having a pragmatic rather than an ideological commitment to a movement.

Tiny houses may help meet the housing needs and aspirations of a small section of the Australian population, in ways that also provide greater diversity and choice in the wider Australian housing market and are consistent with the policy agendas of more mainstream housing advocates, such as increasing affordable housing supply and building at greater density in certain areas. Furthermore, the popularity of the idea of tiny houses, particularly on social media, can indirectly influence more widely held attitudes to housing, certain design principles and the intent of regulatory regimes (Penfold *et al.*, 2018). Nonetheless, the countercultural ambitions of some tiny house advocates in questioning dominant socio-economic paradigms, particularly of consumerism, remain subject to criticism. For example, the carbon footprint of tiny houses, their whole-of-life and embodied energy profiles and the consumer behavior of their inhabitants are not necessarily consistent with the off-grid, sustainable lifestyle claimed by many proponents. In this respect, tiny house living might represent a different form of consumerism rather than a rejection of it.

Tiny house living is not a new phenomenon. Many people around the world live in dwellings that would be considered tiny by contemporary Australian or North

American standards. Many also live in temporary dwellings that can be moved when necessary, either because it suits a mobile lifestyle or because they face occasional challenges that require them to move. Some people live in tiny houses that will in time become larger and the practice of adding to dwellings over time as finance allows and household size and composition dictates is, again, nothing new, even in Australia.

Tiny houses can offer a relatively cheap way to own somewhere to live, even though construction costs *per square meter* can be substantially greater than for more conventional housing. Funding the purchase or construction of a tiny house typically requires some savings, discretionary funds or relatively secure employment income as conventional housing finance can be hard to obtain. While THOW do not necessarily require their occupants to own the land on which they sit, they do require the permission or tolerance of landowners (Alexander *et al.*, 2018; Goodman *et al.*, 2013; Hulse & Milligan, 2014) and even if this is forthcoming, the landowner is likely to face significant regulatory hurdles in allowing a tiny house dweller to park on their land. There is scope to review, simplify and change the regulatory regimes across Australia that affect tiny houses so that they are more consistent and so that tiny houses are not treated *prima facie* as undesirable or as a problematic planning outcome.

The sustainability of tiny houses and tiny house living also illustrates new possibilities for living in ways that are potentially less harmful to the environment. This lies principally in the reduction of material possessions necessitated by small space living, as the total environmental impact of tiny houses compared to other forms has not been calibrated with any degree of precision. While some tiny house dwellers can live off-grid and avoid reliance on networked power or reticulated water and waste systems, it is by no means clear that this form of autonomy is the most efficient, effective or equitable at a societal scale.

Tiny houses appeal in principle to various types of people including some members of the ‘millennial’ generation, some inner-city dwellers who might be part of Florida’s ‘creative class’ (Florida, 2000; Li Ang & Wilkinson, 2008) and members of small yet vocal anti-establishment and minimalist groups (Anson, 2014; Florida, 2000). Tiny house living also appeals to some single, older women; a group in Australia at increasing risk of homelessness, due to insufficient superannuation, relationship breakdown and whose long-term history of renting often means they have little or no property or real estate assets (Petersen & Parsell, 2015). But despite its popularity in some quarters, there are significant barriers to tiny house living, especially those associated with the planning and building regulatory regimes of local governments. THOW sit in a complex regulatory environment and are recognized by most Australian local governments only as caravans with widely differing regulations on how long somebody can live in what are treated as temporary dwellings. Planning and building legislation could however be modified to permit THOW to occupy space on appropriate properties, if compliant with the Building Code of Australia (which might need some modification) and modification with relevant permits regulating waste disposal and water management. For example, the Scenic Rim Regional Council in Queensland (2020) has recently released a ‘Tiny House Fact Sheet’ which clarifies that permanent occupation is possible if various permits identical to those required for an Auxiliary Dwelling Unit (or granny flat) have been obtained.

Tiny house advocates often stress the importance of ‘community’ but mostly live as many other detached house dwellers, except perhaps for their increased use of public resources such as parks, coffee shops or libraries. Greater reliance on public or third spaces (Bosman & Dolley, 2019) is of course not limited to tiny house dwellers and many apartment dwellers in denser urban areas depend also on public realm facilities for space to exercise, play and socialize in larger groups (Gehl, 2011). Paradoxically, some tiny house residents in rural areas reported having to drive long distances to access public resources, employment and education opportunities and social services to the detriment of their ambitions to live more sustainably. However, many of the new suburban developments on the fringes of Australian cities are similarly reliant on communal facilities as the individual backyard shrinks as house sizes do not decline at the same rate as lot sizes (Hall, 2010).

Freedom from debt or from regulation was another strong theme emerging from the research. Many respondents wanted to avoid the obligations associated with a mortgage on a property far from an employment center, including long commuting times, the need for two adults to work and lack of time for family and social life. Some expressed a desire to spend their money (however earned) on experiences rather than material possessions, although of course, this is just another manifestation of consumerism (Bauman, 2004; Smith, 2006). Freedom from regulation was another aspiration apparent among some of our respondents although there is an emerging dichotomy in the tiny house community between those who welcome the inclusion of tiny houses into the housing mainstream through better regulation, and those who want them to retain their autonomy and independence as an element of a countercultural movement. This underlying tension between a desire to be free from government regulations and obligations and a reliance on public infrastructure (such as the road network, public parks and libraries) was rarely mentioned by our respondents but is worthy of further research.

Tiny houses are, of course, no panacea for the wicked problems of housing unaffordability and unsustainable development. They could, however, make a greater contribution to the range of affordable options available in the Australian housing landscape. Perhaps the true significance of tiny houses lies in their capacity to exemplify and prefigure new ways of living in smaller, better designed and better constructed dwellings. In this sense they could perform a similar function to the more conventional show homes commonplace in new medium to large scale suburban residential developments. This prefigurative and disruptive value may help precipitate a paradigm shift in social norms, encourage greater awareness of the waste of resources in much modern residential construction, and encourage a broader social trend to demand smaller and more sustainable housing (Alexander *et al.*, 2018; Kilman, 2016).

In this article we have suggested looking beyond the size, design and construction methods of tiny houses, important as these are (de Oliveira, 2009), to a broader consideration of what is still an embryonic tiny house movement. The expansion and influence of this movement will determine how influential the principles espoused by tiny house advocates are on the wider and more mainstream housing system in Australia and elsewhere. Research on tiny houses is in its infancy and much remains to be done—conceptually, theoretically and empirically. Questions of land and property ownership are perhaps most pressing but further work is also needed on the scope

for developing broader communities of tiny house dwellers that are not subject to the regulatory constraints and negative social perceptions associated with caravan or mobile home parks and lessons might be learned from retirement living developments (Hu *et al.*, 2017). Issues of funding and finance (Hui, 1999) are also important if the full spectrum of people who might consider tiny house living are to be able to access new and more suitable financial products and services. Finally, there is a need for more rigorous assessment of the environmental footprint of tiny houses, including their construction and running costs and the lifestyles associated with them (Wilson & Boehland, 2008).

We might not yet have reached the moment when tiny houses have become a commonplace element of the housing landscape in Australia or North America, but some of the principles of tiny house living are reflective of broader changes in how and where we prefer to live. While residential property ownership for occupation and for renting continues to be seen and promoted as a significant form of wealth accumulation for ‘ordinary Australians’, but there are moves to increase the attractiveness and respectability of long-term renting through new build to rent schemes (CBRE, 2020) and to refocus on the use value as well as exchange value of housing (Moskowitz, 2018). Notions of mobility, flexibility and well-designed housing spaces that are associated with tiny house living are, therefore, becoming more commonplace in housing debates in Australia and reflected in what mainstream housing developers are willing to provide. By providing greater choice in these ways it is possible that some of those who have been neglected by the market—younger and more mobile people and older single women for example—might begin to have their housing needs met more effectively and sustainably.

Tiny houses of all types are still only a very small fraction of the housing stock in Australia and what might be termed the tiny house movement is still embryonic. Nevertheless, this article set out to show there are lessons to be learned from the aspirations and experiences of tiny house dwellers as part of the broader process of seeking to make housing markets and systems more responsive to the needs of all people and to building a more sustainable and equitable housing landscape.

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